supply of quality apples may lead to an increase in their market prices as there will be no takers for the flood of culled fruit entering the markets," he says.

More than 64 million fruit-bearing trees are planted in J&K over 2.15 lakh ha of land producing more than 2.4 MT of fruit. Of them, some 45 million are apple trees, grown in over 70 per cent of land (1.5 lakh ha) and producing over 2.1 MT of the apple annually. The Rs 10,000 crore horticulture sector, which is a major contributor to the J&K economy, directly or indirectly employs 700,000 families or 3.5 million people. Mohammad Amin, technical officer of the Kashmir horticulture department, says that compared to the corresponding period last year, production will drop 5 per cent from the 2.1 MT yield. "The hot dry weather has affected the quality of the apples, particularly the Delicious variety both in terms of colour and size," he says. "During the blooming period, the weather was erratic. We have advised orchardists to irrigate their fields wherever possible, spray suitable nutrients and other chemicals to mitigate the adverse effects of the hot and dry weather."

Likewise, annual apple production in Himachal, according to official data of the state horticulture department, touched 6.7 lakh tonnes (30.3 million boxes) in 2022, but is estimated to be 29 million boxes this year. Subash Chandar, the joint director of horticulture in HP, cites multiple factors, including disease outbreak and floods. The last flood, he says, inflicted losses worth Rs 155 crore on growers. "We won't meet last year's production," he says. "Markets are doing fine, but there is less supply." The department has tasked the University of Horticulture, Solan, to study the impact of climate change on horticulture and take measures to safeguard growers.

At the Azadpur Mandi in Delhi, Asia's largest wholesale market for fruit and vegetables, almost 150 truckloads of apples would arrive daily last harvest season. "Only 50-70 trucks arrive in a day now," says Rakesh Kohli, general secretary, Kashmir Apple Merchants' Association in Delhi's Azadpur, who has been in the fruit trade for more than four decades now. "The decline in production has spiked rates and demand. For example, a kilo of 'A' grade apples is sold between Rs 90 and Rs 140, which is 25 per cent higher than the previous year."



"FARMERS ARE SUFFERING LOSSES IN KASHMIR AND HIMACHAL. WE WANT THE GOVERNMENT TO ANNOUNCE A SPECIAL PACKAGE TO COMPENSATE FOR FLOOD LOSSES IN HIMACHAL, AS WELL AS A MARKET INTERVENTION SCHEME AND CROP INSURANCE FOR GROWERS"

-HARISH CHAUHAN

Convenor, Hill States Horticulture Forum for Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh & Uttarakhand

Growers are also unhappy with the government's removal of the additional 20 per cent tariff it had imposed on agricultural produce, including apples, from the US in 2019, in retaliation to that country raising duties on Indian aluminium and steel exports in 2018. On a visit to the US this June, Prime Minister Narendra Modi reached an agreement to remove the duty. The increased tariff had curtailed apple imports from the US from $145 million in 2017-2018 to $5.27 million in 2022-2023, but its benefit primarily went to other countries such as Iran, Turkey, New Zealand and Chile which acquired the US's market share in India. Apple imports from these countries, per commerce ministry data, grew from $160 million in 2018-19 to $290 million in 2022-23.

The removal of additional duty, though, has not meant any relaxation on the most favoured nation duty on imported apples, which includes products of US origin. It continues to be 50 per cent. The commerce ministry has also imposed a minimum import price of Rs 50 a kg on apple imports from all countries except Bhutan. This move could compensate for some of the dent local growers suffer on account of the bulk of the duty-free apples imported from Iran under the Free Trade Agreement via Afghanistan.

Countering criticism, Union commerce minister Piyush Goyal says there is uniform import duty for all nations now. "No import duty has been reduced," he says. "To support apple production, the Modi government imposed a heavy duty on imported apples. A few months back, we also set a minimum import price for apples." Many at Azadpur Mandi also concur that the removal of the extra tariff will not impact local produce, since US apples will cost Rs 170-180 per kg. This will not make it easy for the Washington apple to gain market share that the relatively cheaper imported varieties will occupy. "People will buy cheaper apples from these countries," says a trade leader.

Yet, growers fear the fall in Washington apple prices will affect premium local fruit. The price of a 20 kg box of Washington apples, for example, may come down to Rs 3,000-3,200 from the current Rs 4,000, competing directly with premium local varieties that sell at Rs 2,500-Rs 3,000. "People will prefer it given its sophisticated packaging and shiny look even if it cannot compete with the Kullu, the Delicious from Himachal or Kashmir, which are crunchier, juicier and red in colour," says Chauhan. Apple-growing is evidently becoming a fruitless pursuit for the Indian farmer. ■